08 · Reflection and Lessons Learned: writing guide

Owner suggestion: each member writes their own personal reflection; Member 3 compiles the team table. **Length:** team part 1 page, each personal reflection about half a page. **Time:** 25 to 30 minutes.

Purpose

Show that you can **learn from the project**: what happened, why, and what you will do differently. Markers look for honesty, depth and links to evidence, not for praise. The brief lists "Reflection & Lessons Learned" as a final deliverable.

Key ideas explained simply

- **Reflection:** thinking back about experience and what you learned from it. Not just "what we did" but "what it meant and what changes".
- **Lessons learned:** specific, reusable knowledge ("do X next time because Y happened").
- **A simple reflection model (Gibbs-style):** What happened? How did I feel? What went well and badly? Why did it happen (analysis)? What did I learn (conclusion)? What will I do next time (action)?

Part 1: Team lessons learned (a table, 1 page)

Area	What went well	What did not go well	Lesson / what we would change	Evidence
Planning and scope				
Agile practice (backlog, sprints, retrospectives)				
Communication and teamwork				
Technical decisions				
Testing and quality				
Risk and change management				
Stakeholder engagement				
Time management and deadlines				

Fill each row with specific events from *your* project. Link each lesson to evidence (a sprint retrospective, a bug, a change request, a decision).

Real events in this project you can reflect on *(use only what truly applies to you)*

- **Scope versus the brief:** the brief asked for payments, microservices and AI fraud detection; the team built a trust-focused marketplace instead (verified identity, buyer-confirmed ratings, moderation). What did that decision teach about scoping, honesty and trade-offs?
- **Testing found a real defect:** simultaneous "mark sold" requests corrupted the stock count; testing before users caught it. What does that teach about testing concurrency and about relying only on manual checks?
- **Environment surprise:** the first fix failed because the database was MariaDB, not MySQL; the lesson about matching development and production environments.
- **Clean demo data:** old test data appeared during the demo; the lesson about separating test data from demo data and backing things up.
- **Time pressure at the end:** documents, demo and polishing compressed into the final days; what would you plan differently?
- **Team of three:** doing the work of the brief's six roles; how you shared roles and what suffered.
- **Agile:** which practices stuck (backlog, retrospectives) and which did not.

Part 2: Individual reflection (one per member, about 250 to 350 words each)

Each member must write their own, in a personal voice. They should not look alike. Use this structure:

1. **My role and what I did** (2 to 3 sentences, specific; matches the contribution page).
2. **A highlight:** something I am proud of and why.
3. **A challenge:** the hardest moment, what caused it, how I handled it.
4. **What I learned:** technical skills and project management skills (for example estimating, communicating, risk thinking, Agile).
5. **What I would do differently:** one or two concrete changes.
6. **How I will use this:** a skill to keep improving or a habit to adopt.

Prompts to unlock writing: What surprised you? What did you underestimate? When did the plan stop matching reality? What did you learn from a teammate? How did you feel when something broke or when it worked?

Part 3: Overall conclusion (3 to 5 sentences, team voice)

What the team achieved, the biggest lesson, and one recommendation for a future team.

Tone and length tips

- First person for the personal parts ("I"), team voice ("we") for the table and conclusion.

- Be honest about difficulties; admitting a mistake and what you learned from it scores better than perfection.
- Avoid generic lines ("teamwork is important"). Anchor each point to an event.
- Do not exaggerate your own contribution; it must match the contribution page and the video.

Common mistakes

- Only describing what was built (that belongs in the Final Report).
- Identical reflections for all members.
- No lessons or no changes for next time.
- Hiding problems.

Checklist

- [ ] Team lessons table with specific, evidence-linked entries
- [ ] One individual reflection per member, each personal
- [ ] Each reflection has a role, highlight, challenge, learning, change, next step
- [ ] Consistent with the contribution page and RACI
- [ ] Short team conclusion